

Chapter 25

The Age of Positivism: Realism, Impressionism, and the
Pre-Raphaelites, 1848–1885

Learning Objectives

1. Define the word positivism, and describe how the rise of positivism, as well as the study of sociology, reflect the dramatic changes occurring in Western Civilization.
2. Assess the differing responses found in English and French art to the social transformations brought about by the Industrial Revolution toward 1850.
3. Track how French Realism changed as it developed from Gustav Courbet to Edouard Manet and Edgar Degas, and lastly to Claude Monet.
4. Describe the different attitudes toward the new medium of photography that surfaced in the 1840s, both by artists and the public in general, and how, in some respects, photography was the perfect visual medium for Age of Positivism.
5. Identify the period's attitude toward the use of iron in architecture.



Gustave Eiffel EIFFEL TOWER, PARIS
1889 (also the date of this photograph). Height 984' (300 m).
Courtesy the Library of Congress.

Europe and the United States in the Mid to Late Nineteenth Century (1 of 2)

- Advances in manufacturing, transportation, and communications created new products and wealth.
 - However, industrial laborers and owners of cottage industries suffered extensively.
- Women demanded suffrage (only achieved in 1920) and many suffragists were also slavery abolitionists.

Europe and the United States in the Mid to Late Nineteenth Century (2 of 2)

- The second half of the nineteenth century has been called the "positivist age" due to its faith in science.
 - The development of the telephone, radio, electrical lighting, vaccines, and disinfectant occurred.
 - Charles Darwin challenged Creation.
- This paralleled the changes in art, but later abstract expression emerged.



EUROPE AND THE UNITED STATES IN THE NINETEENTH CENTURY

In the nineteenth century, Europe and the United States became increasingly industrialized, and many European nations established colonial possessions around the world. Paris was firmly established as the center of the Western art world.

French Academic Architecture and Art

- Public works were decorated with motifs drawn from historic **models—historicism**.
- Historicists often combined allusions to other different historical periods in a single work.
- Orientalist paintings arose, combining Egyptian, Turkish, and Indian cultures through symbolism.

Art and Its Contexts: Orientalism

- The Snake Charmer by Jean-León Gérôme mixes Egyptian, Turkish, and Indian cultures in a fantastical and erotic work.
- Edward Said describes Orientalism as the colonial gaze in which the Orient is viewed as something to possess, an "exotic" playground for the "civilized" European visitor.



Jean-Léon Gérôme THE SNAKE CHARMER
c. 1870. Oil on canvas, 33" x 48-1/8" (83.8 x 122.1 cm).
Clark Art Institute, Williamstown, Massachusetts. Acquired by Sterling and Francine Clark, 1942. (1955.51). Bridgeman Images

Academic Architecture

- Charles Garnier constructed the Paris Opéra (opera house) with a cast-iron frame overlaid with nonstructural "neo-Baroque" decoration.
- The opulent foyer staircase served as a stage for nobility.



Charles Garnier OPÉRA, PARIS
1861–1874.
© akg-images.



GRAND STAIRCASE, OPÉRA
© John Kellerman/Alamy Stock Photo.

Painting and Sculpture (1 of 2)

- *The Birth of Venus* by Alexandre Cabanel represents the taste of the Académie des Beaux-Arts at the mid nineteenth century.
 - A combination of popular mythology and sexual allure characterizes this piece.
 - The won the Prix de Rome and went on to garner three-time top honors at the Salon.



Alexandre Cabanel THE BIRTH OF VENUS
1863. Oil on canvas, 52" x 90" (1.35 x 2.29 m).

Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Hervé Lewandowski.

Painting and Sculpture (2 of 2)

- The works of Jean-Baptiste Carpeaux explore the deviations within the academy.
 - *The Dance* portrays a group of nude dancers in a somewhat spontaneous arrangement.
 - Unlike Neoclassical art, this piece contains figures that are more naturalistic than idealized.



Jean-Baptiste Carpeaux THE DANCE
1867–1868. Plaster, height approx. 15' (4.6 m).
Musée d'Orsay, Paris. © akg-images/Erich Lessing.

Realism and the Avant-Garde

- The **avant-garde**, "advance guard," was created in reaction to rigid academy training.
- Artists gathered to transform modern industrialized and bourgeois society into an ideal state through radical art.
 - Architect Viollet-le-Duc believed that this would sacrifice reputations and reduce sales.

Realism and Revolution (1 of 6)

- The Revolution of 1848 saw the overthrow of the monarchy and establishment of the Second Republic.
 - Conflicts among reformers led to the deaths of over 10,000 working poor.
- Realism is less of a style and more of a commitment to paint the brutalities of the modern world with honesty.

Realism and Revolution (2 of 6)

- Courbet
 - Gustave Courbet (1819–1877) turned to painting poor and ordinary people.
 - *The Stone Breakers*, destroyed in World War II, depicts a young boy and an old man crushing rocks.
 - The figures represent both an obsolete past and a grim future.
 - The work itself was the scale of a history painting.



Gustave Courbet THE STONE BREAKERS
1849. Oil on canvas, 5'3" x 8'6" (1.6 x 2.59 m).

Formerly Gemäldegalerie, Dresden; destroyed in World War II. © Staatliche Kunstsammlungen Dresden/Bridgeman Images.

Realism and Revolution (3 of 6)

- Courbet
 - *A Burial at Ornans* commemorates the funeral of Courbet's grandfather.
 - Genuine sorry of mourners is contrasted by indifference of two Church officials.
 - The painting captures the physical reality of a funeral with awkward numbness.



Gustave Courbet A BURIAL AT ORNANS
1849. Oil on canvas, 10'3-1/2" x 21'9" (3.1 x 6.6 m).
Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Gérard Blot/Hervé Lewandowski.

Realism and Revolution (4 of 6)

- Millet
 - Accusations of political radicalism were leveled against Courbet, and later against Jean-François Millet for his paintings' focus on rural life.
 - *The Gleaners* shows three women gathering left-over grain after harvest in a scene where warm colors contrast extreme poverty.
 - Millet would deny social criticism.



Jean-François Millet THE GLEANERS

1857. Oil on canvas, 33" x 44" (83.8 x 111.8 cm).

Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Jean Schormans.

Realism and Revolution (5 of 6)

- Corot
 - Through a more romantic approach, Corot painted intimate scenes of rural France like *First Leaves, Near Mantes*.
 - Images of peaceful country life held appeal for Parisians sick of the crowded and chaotic metropolis.



Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot FIRST LEAVES, NEAR MANTES
c. 1855. Oil on canvas, 13-3/8" x 18-1/8" (34 x 46 cm).

Carnegie Museum of Art, Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. Photograph © 2016 Carnegie Museum of Art, Pittsburgh. Photo:
Richard Stoner.

Realism and Revolution (6 of 6)

- Bonheur
 - Rosa Bonheur was a popular painter of French farm life.
 - She had to dress in men's clothing (with police permission) to make detailed studies in stockyards and slaughterhouses.
 - *The Horse Fair* was highly praised at the 1853 Salon, which was unusual for a painting of farm animals.



Rosa Bonheur THE HORSE FAIR
1853–1855. Oil on canvas, 8'-1/4" × 16'-7-1/2" (2.45 × 5.07 m).
Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY/
Scala, Florence.

Manet: "The Painter of Modern Life"

(1 of 4)

- Themes of the modern city and politics are key to understanding the trends that developed in Paris at this time.
- Édouard Manet became the unofficial leader of a group of artists and writers who pushed the French Realist tradition into new territory.

Manet: "The Painter of Modern Life"

(2 of 4)

- *Luncheon on the Grass*
 - Manet offered flat, sharply outlined, and starkly lit figures who stand out against their setting.
 - In a nod to Titian's *Pastoral Concert*, a completely naked woman is seated next to two fully clothed bourgeois men.
 - This nudity was scandalous as it was not part of mythological or historical narrative, but within contemporary life.



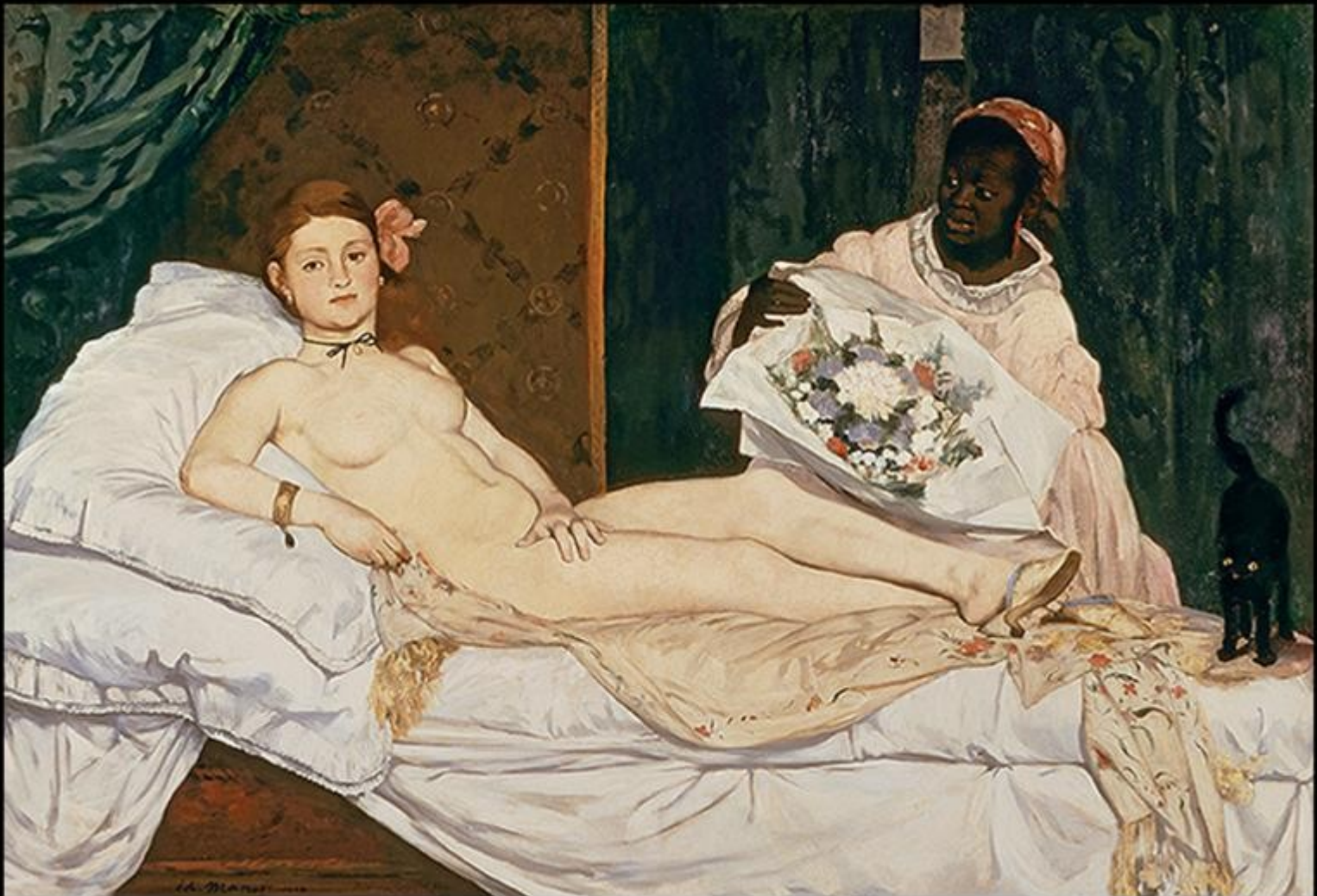
Édouard Manet THE LUNCHEON ON THE GRASS/LE DÉJEUNER SUR L'HERBE
1863. Oil on canvas, 7' x 8'8" (2.13 x 2.64 m).

Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Hervé Lewandowski.

Manet: "The Painter of Modern Life"

(3 of 4)

- *Olympia*
 - The title alludes to a socially ambitious prostitute of the same name in a novel and play by Alexandre Dumas *films*.
 - It is based on Titian's "*Venus*" of *Urbino*, but instead of a curvaceous and round nude, Manet's subject is angular and flattened.
 - The tradition of the accommodating female nude is subverted by her gaze.



Édouard Manet OLYMPIA
1863. Oil on canvas, 4'3" × 6'2-1/4" (1.31 × 1.91 m).
Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay).

Manet: "The Painter of Modern Life"

(4 of 4)

- Later Works
 - *A Bar at the Folies-Bergère* portrays a girl hard at work in a bar, maintaining Manet's dedication to painting modern urban life.
 - The piece acknowledges both her class and gender; both she and the products she sells appear to be available for purchase.



Édouard Manet A BAR AT THE FOLIES-BERGÈRE
1881–1882. Oil on canvas, 37-3/4" x 51-1/4" (95.9 x 130 cm).
The Samuel Courtauld Trust, The Courtauld Gallery, London. (P.1934.SC.234).
© Samuel Courtauld Trust, The Courtauld Gallery, London, UK/Bridgeman Images.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(1 of 9)

- Social effects of urbanization and industrialization in other countries led to movements of art not labeled "Realism," but called the same manner of attention to the same bleak reality the working poor experienced.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(2 of 9)

- Realism in Russia: The Wanderers
 - Reacting against escapist aesthetics of the St. Petersburg Academy of Art, a group of artists reasserted what they called authentic Russian culture.
 - *Bargehaulers on the Volga* evoked sympathy for a group of peasants in a call to action against the labor practices on the Volga River.



Ilya Repin BARGEHAULERS ON THE VOLGA
1870–1873. Oil on canvas, 4'3-3/4" × 9'3" (1.3 × 2.81 m).
State Russian Museum, St. Petersburg. © akg-images.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(3 of 9)

- Realism in the United States: A Continuing Tradition
 - Realism was unbroken in American painting as far back as Colonial portrait painters.
 - Philadelphia artist Thomas Eakins specialized in frank portraits.
 - *The Gross Clinic* was controversial because surgery was deemed an unfit subject for art.



Thomas Eakins THE GROSS CLINIC
1875. Oil on canvas, 8' x 6'5" (2.44 x 1.98 m).

Philadelphia Museum of Art, Pennsylvania. Gift of the Alumni Association to Jefferson Medical College in 1878 and purchased by the Pennsylvania Academy of the Fine Arts and the Philadelphia Museum of Art in 2007. © 2016. Photo The Philadelphia Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(4 of 9)

- Realism in the United States: A Continuing Tradition
 - Winslow Homer was a reporter and illustrator for *Harper's Weekly*, producing works of the Civil War.
 - Later, he created *The Life Line*, depicting a coast guard saving a shipwrecked woman with a breeches buoy.



Winslow Homer THE LIFE LINE
1884. Oil on canvas, 28-3/4" x 44-5/8" (73 x 113.3 cm).
Philadelphia Museum of Art, Pennsylvania. The George W. Elkins Collection, 1924.
© 2016. Photo The Philadelphia Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(5 of 9)

- Realism in the United States: A Continuing Tradition
 - Edmonia Lewis created highly successful busts and medallions of abolitionist leaders and Civil War heroes.
 - Inspired by the struggle of recently freed slaves for equality, she created *Forever Free* to commemorate the Emancipation Proclamation.



Edmonia Lewis **FOREVER FREE**
1867. Marble, 41-1/4 × 22 × 17" (104.8 × 55 × 43.2 cm).
Howard University Gallery of Art, Washington, DC.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(6 of 9)

- Realism in the United States: A Continuing Tradition
 - Henry Ossawa Tanner's painting received favorable critical attention after he moved from Atlanta to Paris.
 - *The Banjo Lesson* is a humanizing image of African-American life, where an elderly man teaches a young boy with serious concentration.



Henry Ossawa Tanner THE BANJO LESSON
1893. Oil on canvas, 49 × 35-1/2" (124.4 × 90 cm).
Hampton University Museum, Virginia. Hampton University's Archival and Museum Collection Hampton University.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(7 of 9)

- Developments in Britain
 - In England, artists looked to art of the Middle Ages and Early Renaissance for beauty, naturalism, and moralizing spirituality they found was lacking.
 - Rossetti's *La Pia de' Tolomei* illustrates a story from Dante's *Purgatory*.
 - It is rich with symbolism, implying that La Pia (the pious one) is a captive within her marriage.



Dante Gabriel Rossetti *LA PIA DE' TOLOMEI*
1868–1869. Oil on canvas, 41-1/2" × 47-1/2" (105.4 × 119.4 cm).
Spencer Museum of Art, The University of Kansas. (1956.0031)

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(8 of 9)

- Developments in Britain
 - William Morris argued for handcrafted objects over gaudy and shoddy industrially-produced goods.
 - He founded a decorating firm to produce a full range of domestic products.
 - Some products were relatively affordable, such as the rush-seated *Chair* shown on the next slide.



Philip Webb and William Morris "SUSSEX" CHAIR and "PEACOCK AND DRAGON" CURTAIN

Chair (by Webb): In production from c. 1865.

Ebonized wood with rush seat, 33" x 16 1/2" x 14" (83.8 x 42 x 35.6 cm).

Curtain (by Morris): 1878. Handloomed jacquard-woven woolen twill, 12'10-1/2" x 11'5-5/8" (3.96 x 3.53 m). Chair and curtain manufactured by Morris & Company. The William Morris Gallery, London Borough of Waltham Forest. The William Morris Gallery, London, E17, England.

Responses to Realism Beyond France

(9 of 9)

- Developments in Britain
 - James Abbott McNeill Whistler sought to satisfy an elitist taste for pure beauty.
 - His art was of pure aesthetic value.
 - *Nocturne in Black and Gold, the Falling Rocket* depicts a fireworks show with several observers in the foreground.
 - It was criticized as unfinished, or as flinging paint in the audience's face.



James Abbott McNeill Whistler NOCTURNE IN BLACK AND GOLD, THE FALLING ROCKET
1875. Oil on panel, 23-3/4" x 18-3/8" (60.2 x 46.7 cm).
The Detroit Institute of Arts. Gift of Dexter M. Ferry Jr. (46.309).
Bridgeman Images.

Art and Its Contexts: Art on Trial in 1877

- The trial that James Abbott McNeill Whistler initiated against critic John Ruskin ended in favor of the artist, whom Ruskin had libeled.
- However, in those days, the person who brought the suit had to pay all court costs; this bankrupted the artist.

Impressionism

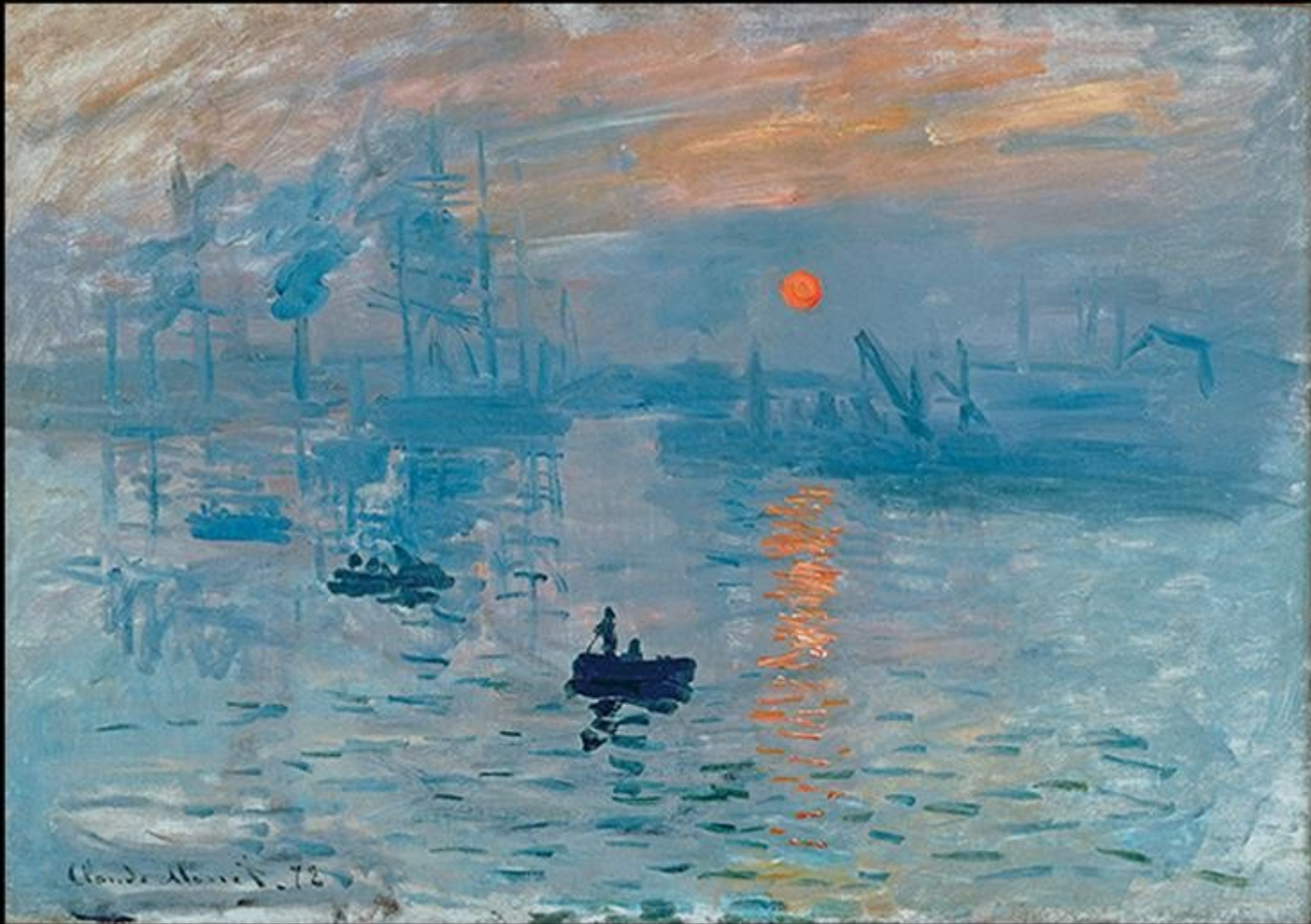
- Artists began to paint outdoors, ***en plein air*** in an effort to record fleeting effects of light and atmosphere.
- A group under the organization of Camille Pissarro urged artists to band into grass-roots organizations rather than rely on state-sanctioned institutions.
 - Their exhibitions drew relative success.

Landscape and Leisure (1 of 6)

- The Franco–Prussian War of 1870 and the deaths of over 20,000 people rocked Paris and led to the diminishment of political commentary in French art.
- Impressionists sought to celebrate semirural outings afforded by the Paris train system.

Landscape and Leisure (2 of 6)

- Monet's painting, *Impression, Sunrise*, was how the Impressionist movement was named.
 - A critic meant for it to mock the open brushstrokes and unfinished look, but Monet and his colleagues felt it aptly described their aim of depicting a fleeting moment.



Claude Monet IMPRESSION: SUNRISE
1872. Oil on canvas, 19" x 24-3/8" (48 x 63 cm).
Musée Marmottan, Paris. Bridgeman Images.

Landscape and Leisure (3 of 6)

- Monet painted the façade of the Rouen Cathedral on over 30 canvases.
 - Rather than for religious reasons, Monet's fascination with this particular cathedral involved the way the light changed the façade constantly.



Claude Monet ROUEN CATHEDRAL, WEST FAÇADE, SUNLIGHT
1894. Oil on canvas, 39-3/8 x 25-7/8" (100.1 x 65.8 cm).
National Gallery of Art, Washington, D.C., Chester Dale Collection (1963.10.179).
Image courtesy the National Gallery of Art, Washington.

Landscape and Leisure (4 of 6)

- Camille Pissarro painted scenes where urban visitors were embedded within a rural countryside.
 - *Wooded Landscape at L'Hermitage, Pontoise* is composed of a village shrouded in a screen of trees.



Camille Pissarro WOODED LANDSCAPE AT L'HERMITAGE, PONTOISE
1878. Oil on canvas, 18-5/16" x 22-1/16" (46.5 x 56 cm).

The Nelson-Atkins Museum of Art, Kansas City, Missouri. Gift of Dr. and Mrs. Nicholas S. Pickard.

Landscape and Leisure (5 of 6)

- Pierre-Auguste Renoir focused his attention on depicting the middle class at leisure.
 - *Moulin de la Galette* shows the relaxed and informal crowd at a dance hall.
 - The artist sought to capture a carefree life, a paradise removed from the real world.



Pierre-Auguste Renoir MOULIN DE LA GALETTE
1876. Oil on canvas, 4'3-1/2" x 5'9" (1.31 x 1.75 m).

Musée d'Orsay, Paris. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais (musée d'Orsay)/Hervé Lewandowski.

Landscape and Leisure (6 of 6)

- Berthe Morisot married Edouard Manet's brother and continued painting even after the birth of her daughter.
 - Her art was dedicated to the lives of bourgeois women, such as in *Summer's Day*.
 - This painting exemplifies the emphasis on formal features in Impressionist painting.



Berthe Morisot SUMMER'S DAY
1879. Oil on canvas, 17-13/16" x 29-5/16" (45.7 x 75.2 cm).
National Gallery, London. Lane Bequest, 1917. © 2016. Copyright The National Gallery, London/Scala, Florence.